I began this personal history with a Preface, so I shall end with an Endnote.

The goddesses of Hinduism come in many forms but only one of them has ever had three breasts – and I say ‘had’ rather than ‘has’ because one of the three disappeared when she first set eyes on the god she was to marry. The goddess in question was named Meenakshi, or ‘fish-eyes’, because those eyes of hers were said to be fish-shaped. Her name carries less weight north of Hyderabad, but turn about and the further south you travel the bigger she becomes – and nowhere bigger than in Madurai, which is very much her city.

Madurai takes its name from the Sanskrit word *madhura*, or ‘sweetness’, as a consequence of the divine nectar showered on the city by the god Shiva as he shook his matted locks. It is undoubtedly an ancient city – if not quite as old as some would want it to be – and at its centre is the great temple complex of Meenakshi Sundareshvara, from which the surrounding streets radiate outwards, like the spokes of a cartwheel. The temple is the hub around which the city revolves, and it has always been so. From the early days of the Pandyas onwards no ruler dared rule without first seeking legitimacy from the temple’s prime deity, Meenakshi.

Of all the thousands of temples dedicated to Lord Shiva, this temple stands alone in giving equal space to his female *shakti* – not Parvati, Uma, Kali, Durga, Chamunda or any of the usual *devi* suspects, but a local girl. Three-breasted Meenakshi grew up to become a mighty conqueror, a warrior-goddess, but could find no one worthy to be her partner – until she attacked Lord Shiva’s abode on Mount Kailas. She overcame Shiva’s army of elemental *bhoothagana*s and even subdued Shiva’s bull Nandi, but the moment she caught sight of Shiva himself she was overwhelmed by love, and knew then that he was her destined husband – whereupon her middle breast vanished.